

How to Tell If Permits Were Pulled

Let's say you're touring a house with your buyers and, although the sellers claim that no remodeling was ever done without a permit, the new addition seems a little "off" to you. Your clients are first-time homebuyers, and you don't want them inheriting a bunch of problems down the road. How can you tell whether permits have been pulled?

Start by determining which jurisdiction has authority for permits in that area. It's probably either the local city or county office. Permits are usually cataloged by your street address. You'll want to contact the appropriate office and determine whether permits were pulled and whether they were closed (finalized). For sewer work, the county should have a sanitarian who would have these answers. In some cases, it's possible that a septic tank still exists even if the sewer has been connected to public sewer.

If permits were not pulled, the city (or county) may require the unpermitted additions to be partially or fully disassembled in order to inspect the quality of the work to make sure it was done up to code levels. If it were not done properly, it will need to be corrected or restored to its original state-a costly endeavor. In some cases, the homeowner can obtain a permit after the fact by paying a fee.

If you're representing a buyer, it's best to get this out of the way before the buyer purchases the property. If you're representing a seller who may have inherited an unpermitted property, investigating the issue can open up a can of worms your seller will then have to address. In other words, proceed with caution.